The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AP

Donald Trump said he was sending a second aircraft-carrier to the Middle East, “in case we don’t make a deal” with Iran on its nuclear programme. The *USS Gerald R Ford*, the world’s largest warship, would set off from the Caribbean “very soon”, he said. The president also called for regime change in Iran. The two sides held indirect talks in Oman last week.

Sultan Ahmed bin Sulayem left his roles as chair and chief executive of **DP World**, an Emirati logistics giant, after his association with Jeffrey Epstein, a dead sex offender, emerged in documents released by America’s Justice Department. Dubai’s government said he would be succeeded by Essa Kazim as chair and Yuvraj Narayan as chief executive. Earlier **Goldman Sachs’s** top lawyer, Kathryn Ruemmler, resigned over her links to Epstein.

America’s annual **inflation** rate fell further than expected in January, to 2.4%. That was down from 2.7% in December and below economists’ expectations of 2.5%. The core rate, which strips out volatile food and energy prices, was in line with expectations at 2.5%. The figures reassured investors that the Federal Reserve will continue to cut interest rates this year.

The **Trump administration** sued **Harvard University**, accusing it of withholding admissions data. The Justice Department said it was investigating whether Harvard has racially discriminated in its admissions process since 2023, when the Supreme Court banned affirmative action, policies that prioritise certain racial groups. Mr Trump has previously withheld federal funds from campuses, including Harvard's, for not complying with his reforms to university policies.

Germany's chancellor, Friedrich Merz, said that the post-war world order "no longer exists" as he opened the Munich Security Conference. Before departing to the forum, Marco Rubio, America's secretary of state, admitted relations with Europe were "at a defining moment". However, he then skipped a planned meeting with European leaders to discuss Ukraine.

Russia's central bank cut interest rates by half a percentage point, to 15.5%. Most economists had expected it to hold rates steady to rein in inflation. The annual inflation rate was 5.6% in December, down from November, but above the bank's 4% target. Still, the bank wants to buoy growth as the economy flags because of Western sanctions and high borrowing costs.

Britain's High Court ruled that the government's banning of **Palestine Action** was unlawful. Ministers had labelled the pro-Palestinian protest group a terrorist organisation, arguing that its activities, which included breaking into a military air base, were a security threat. Just showing support for the group was made punishable by prison, outraging free-speech advocates. The ruling is another blow to Sir Keir Starmer's struggling government.

Figure of the day: 1.4m, the number of Jeffrey Epstein-related emails processed by a group of software engineers for Jmail.world, a website. Read *The Economist*'s analysis of Epstein's network.

Photograph: Alamy

Europe takes stock of its security

On Friday political leaders and defence bigwigs gathered for the annual Munich Security Conference. Few observers expect an upheaval to match that at last year's event, when J.D. Vance, America's vice-president, shocked Europeans by lambasting their record on free speech and political freedom. This time Marco Rubio, the secretary of state, who holds more orthodox foreign-policy views, will lead the American delegation.

The meeting comes as a shake-up of NATO's military command structure is under way. This week the alliance announced that America would take over the bloc's maritime command, but hand over several other top posts to European countries. More changes are expected to follow. The alliance's defence ministers met in Brussels on Thursday. Europeans, reeling from Donald Trump's recent threats to take Greenland from a NATO member, were somewhat reassured by Elbridge Colby, the Pentagon's policy chief. He spoke, relatively conventionally, of a NATO based on "partnership rather than dependency", and urged Europeans to be "pragmatic".

Photograph: Getty Images

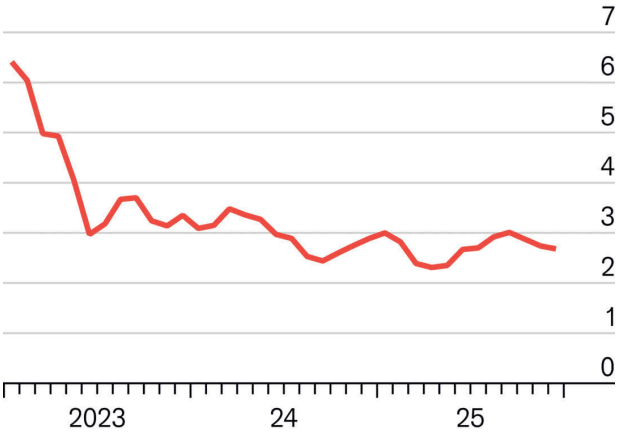
Some (possibly brief) respite from inflation in America

Before Donald Trump's tariffs, America had come tantalisingly close to vanquishing inflation. In April of last year annual inflation was 2.3%, just above the Federal Reserve's target of 2%. After that it shot up, reaching 3% in September, then dipped to 2.7%. This year it could finally decline to the Fed's target.

According to figures released by the Bureau of Labor Statistics, the annual rate fell to 2.4% in January, slightly more than expected. Tariff chaos has not, as feared, caused a destabilising spiral of worsening inflation expectations and rising prices. The jobs market, while solid, has weakened over the past year. Still, another Trumpian twist could be coming. The economy will soon feel the effects of the fiscal giveaways in the "Big, Beautiful" tax bill. Among them could be higher demand and prices.

Inflation frustration

United States, consumer prices,
% increase on a year earlier



Source: LSEG Workspace

Photograph: Getty Images

A dark moment for Japan's progressives

At a snap election on February 8th Japan's ruling centre-right Liberal Democratic Party, led by Takaichi Sanae, the country's first female prime minister, won its biggest victory in the post-war era.

The main centre-left opposition, the Centrist Reform Alliance, suffered a humiliating defeat, shrinking from 173 seats to 49 in the lower house. Online, the party had acquired the unflattering nickname "5G", a play on the Japanese word for "old man", *oji-san*, in reference to the fact that its leaders were men in their 60s and 70s. Several of these old men stepped aside after the defeat, and on Friday the CRA's lawmakers elected Ogawa Junya as their next leader. At a mere 54-years-old, he is a comparative whippersnapper.

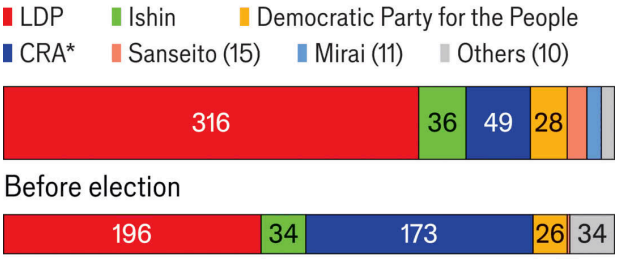
Mr Ogawa has promised to rebuild the party and fight for the liberal causes that Ms Takaichi spurns. The LDP's thumping mandate means that is likely to be an unrewarding pursuit.

Winning big

Japan, National Diet

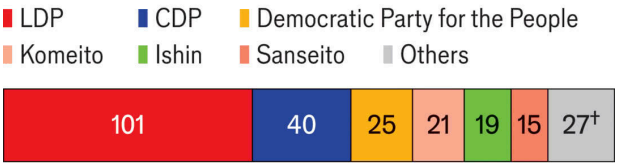
House of Representatives, elected Feb 8th 2026

Total seats=465



House of Councillors, elected Jul 20th 2025

Total seats=248



*Merger of CDP and Komeito †Includes one vacant seat

Sources: Japanese government; press reports

Photograph: Getty Images

The crackdown on dissent in America

Don Lemon will be arraigned in federal court in Minnesota on Friday. Last month the former CNN anchor, a frequent critic of President Donald Trump, covered a protest in St Paul, Minneapolis's neighbouring city, where activists stormed into a church during a service led by a pastor who was also a field director for Immigration and Customs Enforcement. According to the Department of Justice, this violated the congregation's civil rights.

The indictment, which also lays out charges against another journalist and seven protesters, accuses Mr Lemon of having "peppered [the pastor] with questions" in an "attempt to oppress and intimidate him". On Tuesday Mr Lemon said he would be represented by Joseph Thompson, until recently a leading prosecutor in the US attorney's office that is going after him. Mr Thompson is one of 14 prosecutors to have left the office this year in apparent protest. That leaves fewer to pursue the likes of Mr Lemon.

Photograph: Warner Bros. Pictures

Withering reviews for “Wuthering Heights”

Emerald Fennell’s adaptation of “Wuthering Heights” caused conniptions from the moment the project was announced in 2024. People objected to the fact that Australian actors, Margot Robbie and Jacob Elordi, would play Cathy and Heathcliff. After all, Emily Brontë’s novel is set in Yorkshire in the late 18th century. Many also thought that Heathcliff, described by Brontë as a “dark-skinned gypsy in aspect”, should have been played by a non-white actor. Some objected to the extravagant and defiantly anachronistic costumes.

Ms Fennell described writing the screenplay as an exercise in wish-fulfilment. She admits that she reshaped the plot and the characters in her screenplay; the result is an erotic fever dream, a bodice-ripper with a tragic ending. Some who don’t like that approach are reading “Wuthering Heights”, as one wrote online, “so that I can give the adapt[at]ion the hate it deserves”. It’s now showing in cinemas.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which Manhattan venue is home to the New York Knicks?

Thursday: Who is currently fifth in line to the British throne?

I’ve liked lots of people ‘til I went on a picnic jaunt with them.

Bess Truman